

SENSE OF PURPOSE PM Modi heads out with other BJP worthies after an NDA parliamentary meeting, Aug. 5

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BJP GOES HEAD HUNTING

To reset the ideological compass and manage a transition to a post-Modi era, the BJP-RSS are taking their time over choosing a national president

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

JUST WHEN IT SEEMED THE BJP WAS FINALLY getting set to elect a president, the needle moved backward again, with the imperative of finding a new vice-president for the country first. Never mind that it has been more than a year since current president Jagat Prakash Nadda's term came to an end—this after an extension of a year and a half from the original retirement date of January 20, 2023. The vice-presidential election is due on September 9, followed perhaps by a cabinet reshuffle and, of course, the Bihar election.

What is holding up the process? The ideological hand of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) perhaps, which seems to have reclaimed its position behind the steering wheel after the BJP's underwhelming 240-seat tally in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. That setback prompted the Sangh to demand a course correction. No longer content to watch from the sidelines, it has also been pressing for more say in appointments, campaign narratives and transitions at the top. So it is with